

+ Prime focus

Helping you get ahead of the herd at Beef Australia 2018

Like most of those associated with the beef industry, the Queensland Rural and Industry Development Authority (QRIDA) is gearing up for the premier beef event in Australia - Beef Australia 2018 being held in Rockhampton from 6 - 12 May.

As a strong supporter of Queensland's beef industry for more than 20 years, we are looking forward to attending the event and meeting with beef producers about how our low interest loans and grants can help them get ahead of the herd and pursue their business goals.

If you are attending Beef Australia 2018 be sure to visit us at the **Sidney Kidman Pavilion** to speak with us about how our loans and grants could help your enterprise.



More information about our involvement at the event and the support we provide for beef producers is available at www.qrida.qld.gov.au/beef2018

QRIDA - a proud supporter of Beef Australia 2018



Time to start talking about succession

Solid succession planning is crucial to Queensland's farming families and the future of the state's rural industries as a whole, yet many farming families don't have concrete plans in place for the future transfer of their business.

If you are thinking about securing your succession plans, now is the time to look into applying for a Farm Management Grant from QRIDA, with applications for the 2017-2018 round of funding closing on 30 June 2018.

These grants assist eligible Queensland primary producers or their relatives offset the cost of professional advice regarding succession planning from accountants, succession advisors or solicitors.

Providing up to 50 per cent of the amount paid for professional advice (to a maximum of \$2,500 for each financial year the scheme is available), the grants allow farming families to start talking about succession with the peace of mind that some financial costs of the process will be covered.

More than 400 Queensland farming families have accessed the rebates since they were introduced in 2017, resulting in more than \$730,000 being provided to help families plan their farming future.

To receive a rebate for a financial year, an application must be received in that year. This means if you have received a grant in a previous financial year you can apply again for this financial year.

Applications for this financial year close on 30 June 2018 and can be made online at applyonline.qrida.qld.gov.au.

For further information or assistance with your application contact us on **Freecall 1800 623 946**.

Farm Management Grants are delivered in Queensland by QRIDA on behalf of the Queensland Government.

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From the CEO's desk

We've hit the ground running at QRIDA in 2018, starting off the year with the opening of the Farm Debt Restructure Office on 2 January.

The Roma based Office was established to help producers experiencing financial distress access expert financial information and analysis on their farm business.

The introduction of the Office is just one of many new initiatives and programs we've been involved in over the past 18 months that are bringing real benefits and assistance to Queensland's agricultural sector when they need it most.

In fact, the developments and additions to our suite of assistance programs that have been rolled out over this time have really allowed QRIDA to offer a full package of assistance to those who want to make a start in agriculture.

We've seen this with the introduction of Farm Management Grants early last year providing an avenue for people to start talking succession with their family members and making concrete plans for the future of their family farm.

The Queensland Government's elimination of stamp duty on family farm transfers from 1 July 2016 has also provided many benefits for Queensland farming families.

The removal of stamp duty for family farm purchases also compliments our First Start Loans which continue to offer an affordable way for young producers to make their start in agriculture – these loans provide up to \$2 million in low interest finance for producers to purchase their first farm, become a partner in the existing family operation or establish their enterprise in stages to achieve viability.



QRIDA CEO Cameron MacMillan

At QRIDA we're passionate about the profitable future of Queensland's agricultural sector and I'm pleased to see that our involvement in the 'succession journey' of farming families is allowing producers to take succession into their own hands and realise their farming dreams.

I'm looking forward to meeting with farming families at Beef Australia 2018 in Rockhampton from 6 – 12 May. Please come and visit our display in the Sidney Kidman Pavilion to find out more about how we can help you start your farming future.

- Cameron MacMillan

Beefing up infrastructure boosts efficiency and sustainability



QRIDA client, Peter Magoffin's, cattle on his property near Longreach

Queensland's beef producers are as resilient as they come and Peter Magoffin, a fourth-generation grazier from Melrose Station near Longreach, is no exception.

Owning and operating a large beef enterprise through one of Australia's worst droughts on record can prove quite the challenge but Peter has held his ground and is well set up for a sustainable future in beef production despite less than favourable weather conditions.

Support from QRIDA in the way of low interest Drought and Sustainability Loans has contributed to Peter's current position and continued prospects of a profitable future in beef.

"We've been able to do a substantial amount of improvement work at an interest rate we just wouldn't have been able to get anywhere else," Peter said.

Peter, who runs two properties which have been in the family for over 100 years, most recently used a Sustainability

Loan in 2014 to upgrade property infrastructure and increase the efficiency of managing activities like mustering and drafting cattle.

The loan allowed for the purchase and installation of a pneumatic cattle crush – providing improved pressure control, less maintenance, better safety and reduced stress on the cattle.

Peter says it enables the yard work to be completed with just "two and a dog" instead of seven people.

The finance from QRIDA has also enabled Peter to improve the water infrastructure on his properties to give his livestock a reliable supply of water and the ability to graze more widely – something that is crucial during the hot, dry seasons.

"We've seen the full effect of the drought in the past and the improvements we've made to water infrastructure means we can safely and reliably carry bigger numbers," he said.

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+ QRIDA assistance

Access to experts when times are tough



Manager of the Farm Debt Restructure Office, Daniel Elder

Photo Marguerite Cuddihy / News Corp

Farmers experiencing financial hardship now have access to the Farm Business Analysis Assistance program, which provides unbiased, no-cost and no-obligation assessment from a rural finance specialist.

This assistance is provided by the Farm Debt Restructure Office, a branch of QRIDA that operates independently of the organisation's traditional financial assistance and lending department.

The program provides eligible producers with a pathway to a panel of service providers that offer independent expert financial information and analysis of their farm business.

Manager of the Farm Debt Restructure Office, Daniel Elder, says the assistance program intends to help producers in financial difficulty before it is too late.

"The assistance aims to help producers make informed business decisions regarding the future of their enterprise," he said.

"We're hoping it will assist in early identification of financial distress and allow producers to have the time and ability to make beneficial changes to their business so that they can enjoy a profitable future in primary production."

"I'm based in Roma and available to speak with producers about the assistance, eligibility requirements and the process for applying – contact me to discuss how we may be able to help."

Daniel can be contacted by phoning **Freecall 1800 623 946** or emailing daniel.elder@qrida.qld.gov.au

More information is available at www.qrida.qld.gov.au/fdro

"...the improvements we've made to water infrastructure means we can safely and reliably carry bigger numbers...."

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The new solar watering points are much safer than windmills and have reduced labour, time and costs for Peter - "there's no need to cart diesel around anymore. We know we've got water there, and [they're] not going to need any maintenance in my lifetime," he said.

Peter is grateful for the efficiencies the assistance has created for his business and the relationship he has developed with QRIDA throughout the process.

"QRIDA understands not just ag, but all the individual regions – everyone we've spoken to [at QRIDA] understood where we are and what we're trying to get done."

For more information about QRIDA's range of loans visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au or **Freecall 1800 623 946**.

Free up cashflow during the drought

The recent mixed weather conditions experienced across the state has again shown that Queensland is a state of contrasts – some regions have received much needed rain, whilst others have not received as much as they had hoped.

Regardless of the amount of rain received, many producers are still reeling from the effects of years of drought and need help to free up cashflow until conditions improve.

QRIDA's low interest Drought Assistance Concessional Loans continue to help producers be proactive during these uncertain times by offering up to \$1 million to refinance debt, assist cashflow, fund restocking and reduce the financial burden caused by dry conditions.

Craig Turner, QRIDA's Manager of Client Relations, says many producers have reduced interest costs with these loans.

"It's been a rough couple of years and it's a positive step to work on those parts of your business you can control," he said.

"We encourage you to consider refinancing to give yourself some breathing space. The reduced repayment pressure will give you peace of mind if the drought continues, and if you get more rain you'll still have saved yourself some money and freed up cashflow for your recovery."

With a 3.09% interest rate for loans drawn down from 1 February 2018 and an interest-only period of up to five years, refinancing to this loan can have a big impact.

"Currently, the average Drought Loan client is refinancing around \$600,000 in eligible debt and for every one percent difference in interest rate, the saving is around \$6,000 per year, or \$30,000 over five years," Mr Turner said.

Applications for Drought Assistance Concessional Loans close on 30 June 2018. To find out more contact us on **Freecall 1800 623 946**.

Drought Assistance Concessional Loans are delivered in Queensland by QRIDA on behalf of the Australian Government.

+ Regional update



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Biosecurity threats not to be taken lightly

Recent heavy rainfall and localised flooding has brought biosecurity concerns into focus, especially in the banana industry. All primary producers are encouraged to consider the impact of not addressing biosecurity threats within their operation and supply chain.

Our Sustainability Loans are purpose-built to assist you implement biosecurity protocols by funding equipment and infrastructure upgrades, improving fencing and reconfiguring on-farm transport interfaces. Loan terms can be set to suit your cash flow and, with no fees and charges and low interest rates, they allow you to implement your biosecurity plan cost effectively.



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Talks of succession following TC Debbie

Business is brisk with cane growers and cattle breeders turning their attention to succession after managing the impacts of TC Debbie. QRIDA has a tailor-made combination of products to assist with farm succession.

Farm Management Grants are available to assist with advice on succession and, when the advice has been put into practice, First Start Loans provide the vehicle to bring the next generation into the primary production enterprise. Regardless of whether succession is occurring on a staged basis or one transaction, these loans have a role to play in ensuring the transition is effectively financed.



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Next generation dairy farmers show promise

I have been encouraged by the increased optimism demonstrated by dairy farmers in my area of late. QRIDA has been able to provide them with low interest loans to assist with additional property purchases, transition to the next generation through succession and upgrades to plant and equipment ensuring improved water and energy efficiency.

The Queensland Dairyfarmers' Organisation is also making farm succession a priority and QRIDA are looking forward to assisting their members with information on how to access Farm Management Grants and First Start Loans.



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Flooding recovery on track

Producers in Bundaberg and North Burnett have accessed NDRRA grants and loans to assist recovery from the Central Coast flooding event. The positive news is how well the region has recovered with many graziers noting it is the best they've seen the area in over 20 years. With grant assistance closing in April, producers are reminded NDRRA loans will remain available if they need additional support to recover from the flooding.

In spite of improved conditions there is still opportunity to utilise a Drought Assistance Concessional Loan to restock or provide cash flow relief as your enterprise recovers from the impact of drought over recent years.



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Off to a busy start

It has been a hectic start to my time with QRIDA. Two months in and I have had the opportunity to speak with many producers representing the diverse commodities produced in my region.

I've presented at a number of forums discussing First Start and Sustainability Loans, how Drought Assistance Concessional Loans can assist with improved cashflow and the opportunity for producers impacted by Boxing Day storms to access NDRRA loans to help with necessary repairs.

I am keen to meet with you on-farm and discuss how QRIDA can improve your profitability and productivity - contact me to talk more.



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Mixed fortunes for Central and West QLD

Contrasting fortunes sum up the situation for producers in my area. To the West some graziers have had life-changing rainfall whilst others contemplate their options. Drought Assistance Concessional Loans can assist with restocking or relieve cashflow pressure through refinancing or borrowing required funds at low interest rates.

Late Summer rain provided the opportunity for farmers to sow mung beans and sorghum in the Central Highlands and there's a good moisture profile for those sowing Winter crop.

Come and see me at the local shows and field days I'm attending in May and June.



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Options to start operations on staged basis

Property purchases and succession have been the main activity in my region whilst dry conditions have reduced the number of capital expenditure projects undertaken by graziers.

We actively encourage those wanting to enter primary production to consider working on a staged plan to progress to full time primary production. Owning cattle in the first instance and leasing country may be the best way to build equity and get a firm footing to develop a grazing operation - QRIDA understands this and will work with you to determine the appropriate loan conditions and milestones to make your plans reality.



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Gearing up for BEEF Australia 2018

All roads lead to Rockhampton for BEEF Australia 2018! This event provides QRIDA with the perfect opportunity to introduce our new Regional Area Manager for the region, John Metelli. John has a wealth of experience in providing financial solutions and support to rural clients, having worked throughout central and western Queensland.

John is excited to be covering Capricornia encourages producers in the area to make contact to arrange on-farm appointments. If you will be at BEEF Australia 2018, come and meet with John and other members of the regional network to discuss your plans for your business.



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Drought and flood assistance available

The late Summer has been a period of mixed weather in my area. Rain was widespread however the effectiveness of turning the seasons around has been inconsistent. It doesn't rain money and recovery for those who received good rainfall will take time. Other graziers are faced with further destocking as they failed to experience a normal season.

I encourage graziers to call me to discuss their situation and determine which of QRIDA's schemes can assist them best. Loans to ease cashflow constraints during drought are available as is the opportunity to access funds to recover from the impact of major flooding.

Disclaimer: Information provided by QRIDA is general information only and has been prepared without taking into account your individual objectives, financial situation and needs. Before applying for financial assistance or making any decision, you should obtain and read a copy of the relevant program guidelines and seek advice from your legal, business and financial advisers to determine your eligibility for, and the terms of the relevant financial assistance. You should note that past grants of financial assistance are not a reliable indicator of eligibility for future grants of financial assistance. The information provided by QRIDA has been taken from sources believed to be reliable however QRIDA does not represent that the information is accurate or complete and it should not be relied upon as such. QRIDA does not assume any common law duty of care towards you in providing the information and QRIDA will not be liable for any loss or damage however caused (including by the negligence of QRIDA), suffered or incurred by you in connection with information provided by QRIDA.